Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Maya Angelou's "My Arkansas"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of imagery's contribution—with a focus on the three central comparisons—to the subject of Maya Angelou's "My Arkansas" include

alliteration,
allusion,
chiaroscuro,
connotation,
consonance,
diction,
epanalepsis,
free verse,
imagery,
liminality,
metalepsis (transumption),
metaphor,
metonymy,
paradox,
personification,
pun,
resonance,
setting,
sigmatism,
simile,
speaker,
symbolism,
synæsthesia,
theme,
tone, and
zeugma.

The young Literary Criticism contestant should recognize that the poem's imagery finds its strongest expression in the poem's two similes, "old crimes like moss pend / from popular trees" (lines 3-4) and "dusk no more shadows / than the moon" (lines 12-13). The dark symbolism resonating (Billie Holiday's "strange fruit") through the visual imagery of pending moss—the lynching associated with both the ante-bellum South and the Jim Crow era—into the second stanza's seeming personification of the natural order, which reflects the darkness of ignorance: even in the brightness of the noon's potential enlightenment (line 11's incandescence as impassioned endeavor) falters. The symbolic sunrise's hesitation (line 8) preponderates the speaker's poignant observation: "Today is yet to come / in Arkansas" (lines 17-18), and the alliteratively connotative allusion, "It writhes" (line 19), serves to complement the two similes.

The final stanza's comparing of the long-awaited enlightenment to something writhing evokes both the visual imagery of the first stanza's hanging bodies and, through embedded allusion, the first sin. The epanaleptic bracketing ("deep brooding" and awful / waves of brooding") of the past and the present and, optimistically, the future points to the liminality of the poem. The temporal threshold of the speaker's home, Arkansas, has "yet" to be crossed; the old hates and the metonymic ante-bellum lace have not been discarded (lines 14-16). The liminality of the potentiality of "deep brooding" (line 1) finds promised actuality in the image of the brooding's "writh[ing] in awful waves" (line 20).

The young writer might have something to say about the final stanza's "Old hates and / ante-bellum lace, are rent / but not discarded" as zeugma. The accusation of the pivotal line, "The past is brighter yet," might be recognized for the paradox that is informed by chiaroscuro (following the stanza's imagery) and synæsthesia (something temporal being treated as something visual).